Minerals

Calcium is needed for bone and teeth mineralization and maintenance. The amount of calcium a child needs is determined in part by the consumption of other nutrients, such as protein, phosphorus and vitamin D, as well as the child's rate of growth.

Iron requirement during childhood is needed for growth and for increase in the haemoglobin concentration. Dietary lack of iron accompanied by hookworm infestation can lead to anaemia. Zinc is essential for proper development. It is needed for wound healing, proper sense of taste, proper growth, and normal appetite.

30%–50% of aneamia in children and other age groups is caused by iron deficiency (World Health Organization 2007).

Vitamins

The incidence of Vitamin A deficiency is high. The recommended intake for B vitamins is based on the energy intake. The dietary intake of vitamin C for pre-schoolers is the same as for adults i.e., 40 mg/day

Dietary Guidelines

Transition from an infant diet to a regular adult diet should be smooth and gradual. Factors that need to be considered while planning a diet for a preschool child are:

- The food should be interesting and attractive. For example, chapattis, poori and bread slices can be cut into interesting shapes to make eating interesting for a child.
- The diet should include enough quantity and quality of different nutrients. They should be encouraged to have milk every day. Milk can be given with delicious flavours.
- Plenty of fruits and vegetables are needed for proper elimination.
- Fruits are given raw or in the form of simple desserts.

DO YOU KNOW?

Food Jags- Patterns of eating in which very few food items are eaten with the exclusion of all the others for a long period of time

Table 9 Balanced diet for preschool children

		Quantity(portions)	
Food groups	**g/portion**	**1-3 years**	**4-6 years**
Cereals and millets	30	2	4
Pulses	30	1	1
Milk (ml)	100	5	5
Roots and tubers	100	1	1
Green leafy vegetables	100	0.5	0.5
Other vegetables	100	0.5	1
Fruits	100	1	1
Sugar	5	3	4
Fats / Oils (visible)	5	5	5

Source: Dietary Guidelines for Indians - A manual, National Institute of Nutrition, ICMR, Hyderabad, India (2010)

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